



ASLIVER OF HOPE

Despite being far from the podium, it turned out to be **India's most successful Olympic** table tennis outing, primarily thanks to its female paddlers.

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Gender-equal Olympics. That was the motto of Paris 2024.

For India's table tennis contingent, that equality was merely quantitative. When it came to performance, the three women paddlers outdid their male counterparts by a fair margin.

Manika Batra and Sreeja Akula started off the dream fortnight by making it to the singles

pre-quarterfinal, a first for Indian table tennis. Later in the team championship, where India's men and women featured for the very first time, Archana Kamath joined the party as the women went one step further.

A place in an Olympic quarterfinal for an Indian was something that even an ardent table tennis fan would have found hard to believe until recently. India's female outfit

took advantage of a favourable draw to stun fourth-seed Romania and then stretch Germany before exiting in the quarterfinals.

The men, on the other hand, had to be content with either faring below par or living up to their billing. Achanta Sharath Kamal, the old warhorse, was the talk of the town heading into the quadrennial extravaganza. Not only was he featuring in his fifth Olympics —